

FOUR FRAGMENTS

By a Lady

SCENE I: THE LETTER

Drawing room. A small writing table with paper, pen, ink. THE LADY sits very straight. THE OTHER LADY stands behind her chair, brisk, invested.

THE OTHER LADY

Come now. There is no harm in it. Every woman should know how she appears when she wishes to be admired.

THE LADY

I am not acquainted with anyone I should care to write to.

THE OTHER LADY

Then leave the address empty.

(decisive)

Write to your *dream* gentleman. Sign it. I shall see that it reaches the proper hands.

THE LADY

I do not believe I dream very boldly.

THE OTHER LADY

(smiling)

That may be corrected. Begin.

THE LADY

(reading as she writes)

"Sir,"

THE OTHER LADY

Too formal. You wish to seem approachable.

THE LADY

"Dear,"

THE OTHER LADY

Better.

THE LADY

"I hope this letter finds you in good health."

THE OTHER LADY

Health is assumed. What do you hope?

A pause.

THE LADY

"I hope we may be acquainted."

THE OTHER LADY

Modest. Perhaps something warmer.

THE LADY

"I am a quiet woman, with little to recommend me in terms of rank or wealth."

THE OTHER LADY

Ah, no.

(kindly)

Never diminish yourself at the outset.

THE LADY

I wished to be honest.

THE OTHER LADY

Honesty must come later, if at all.

(leaning in)

What do you wish for?

THE LADY

"I hope to be thought agreeable."

A pause.

THE OTHER LADY

That's it?

THE LADY

I should be content with that.

THE OTHER LADY

Perhaps something more... inspiring.

THE LADY

"I would be grateful for the chance to be known."

THE LADY nods at the paper. Then, deliberately:

THE LADY (CONT'D)

(reading)

"Signed,"

THE LADY makes a large, confident flourish beneath the word.

THE OTHER LADY takes the letter, glances it over once, then drops it back onto the table.

THE OTHER LADY

Ah. Never mind.

THE OTHER LADY turns away.

THE LADY straightens her letter carefully on the desk.

END

SCENE II: FIRST MEETING

A quieter edge of the room or a garden path. THE LADY stands apart. THE GENTLEMAN approaches with practiced ease.

THE GENTLEMAN
You keep yourself very well out of reach.

THE LADY
I have found it prudent.

THE GENTLEMAN
Ah. Prudence.

THE GENTLEMAN enjoys the word.

THE GENTLEMAN (CONT'D)
I am fond of the hunt myself, finding out just how to approach each prey, the testing of skill until they are finally--

THE GENTLEMAN pauses.

THE GENTLEMAN (CONT'D)
--caught.

THE LADY laughs lightly.

THE LADY
I've only been caught once, sir, and I do not intend to repeat the experience.

THE GENTLEMAN
(amused)
Only once? By whom?

THE LADY
An officer of the law.

THE GENTLEMAN laughs, then checks himself.

THE GENTLEMAN
You do not mean that as a flirtation.

THE LADY declines to answer.

THE GENTLEMAN (CONT'D)
Then... were you doing something illegal?

THE LADY considers this honestly.

THE LADY
I don't know. I never did find out what was in that package.

THE GENTLEMAN

(smiling)

How very mysterious. And what do you expect, now?

THE LADY

I can expect nothing.

THE GENTLEMAN

You know, some people come here hoping to be caught.

A beat.

THE LADY

I know.

THE LADY looks at him with a small, knowing smile.

THE GENTLEMAN

Perhaps you might save a dance for me this evening?

THE LADY

If you wish it.

THE GENTLEMAN

I do.

(seductively)

I have found that upon the dancefloor, it is very difficult to evade capture.

THE LADY

(smiling)

Indeed? I think I shall manage.

THE GENTLEMAN takes THE LADY's hand and presses a kiss on it.

THE GENTLEMAN

Until we meet again.

THE GENTLEMAN takes his leave.

THE LADY watches him leave, deep in thought.

END

SCENE III: AFTER THE DANCE

A drinks table. Music has just ended; the room is settling.

THE LADY rushes to the table, grinning widely, and gulps down a full glass of water.

THE GENTLEMAN enters, flushed and pleased with himself.

THE GENTLEMAN

(delighted)

No woman has ever stolen me before.

THE GENTLEMAN laughs, repeating it under his breath, savoring the novelty.

THE OTHER LADY enters, clearly less amused.

THE OTHER LADY

(cold)

I don't believe I have ever been stolen from.

THE LADY freezes, then busies herself filling glasses for the other dancers.

THE GENTLEMAN

(oblivious)

I scarcely knew what was happening until it had already happened.

THE OTHER LADY

(warm, to GENTLEMAN)

How spirited of you, my dear.

THE GENTLEMAN

It was exhilarating!

THE OTHER LADY

(polite)

If you'll excuse me, I have a thirst to quench.

THE OTHER LADY steps towards the drinks table, placing herself between the other two.

THE LADY offers a glass of water, but THE OTHER LADY does not accept immediately.

THE OTHER LADY (CONT'D)

My girl, are you enjoying yourself?

THE LADY

(uncertain)

Yes, miss.

THE OTHER LADY

(sweetly)

Have any of the gentlemen caught your eye, perhaps?

A beat.

THE LADY

(looking down)

No, miss.

THE OTHER LADY

Good.

(smiling)

I only wish to avoid misunderstandings. If ever a gentleman should catch your eye...

THE OTHER LADY takes the glass now, hand and all.

THE LADY holds for one terrifying moment.

THE OTHER LADY (CONT'D)

(menacing)

... You will tell me at once.

THE LADY

Yes, miss. At once.

THE OTHER LADY nods, satisfied, and moves away.

THE LADY exhales, slowly, controlled.

END

SCENE IV: THE RIBBON

A parlour, late evening. Guests linger. THE LADY is among them.

THE GENTLEMAN and THE OTHER LADY enter together, visibly disheveled. His cravat is loose, his hair mussed. Her dress is immaculate. A ribbon is tied to HIS WRIST. The long end trails freely in HER HAND, played with idly.

THE LADY
(softly, to THE GENTLEMAN)
Your cravat is undone.

A beat.

THE GENTLEMAN startles, then steps away from THE OTHER LADY to fix it.

THE OTHER LADY
(idly, to the room)
I do so hope it was dark enough that none recognized me.

THE OTHER LADY lets the ribbon slide through her fingers. It trails after him, then falls.

THE OTHER LADY surveys the room, attention already elsewhere.

THE OTHER LADY (CONT'D)
His parents would be quite besides themselves. He might even lose his inheritance.

THE GENTLEMAN finishes his cravat, pauses, then makes to fix his hair as well.

THE LADY
(gently)
He has no parents. He is an orphan. He has already inherited.

THE OTHER LADY turns slowly towards THE LADY, studying her now.

THE OTHER LADY
Are you interested in him?

A pause.

THE LADY
Are you?

THE OTHER LADY glances back, not at him, but at the hand that was holding the ribbon. Her fingers brush together, as if expecting it to still be there.

A longer pause.

THE OTHER LADY
(languid)

No...

THE OTHER LADY turns away, attention fully lost now.

THE GENTLEMAN is finished with his appearance, notices *THE LADY*, and *TAKES HER HANDS IN HIS*.

THE LADY looks down at their joined hands. Then up at *THE GENTLEMAN*. He is smiling encouragingly.

THE LADY gives him a small, knowing smile while she gently withdraws her hands.

THE LADY
Ah. Never mind.

THE GENTLEMAN's smile fades as *THE LADY* turns away.

THE RIBBON lies discarded on the floor.

THE GENTLEMAN stands alone, hands empty.

END